

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

PIA3142 | WEEK 4: SAUL ALINSKY'S RULES FOR RADICALS

THE PUZZLE

Recall that one of the critiques we made of "structuralist" approaches is that while structural factors matter (because they determine the context in which social movements operate), they do not determine *outcomes*, independently of what people actually choose to do.

As we said, outcomes are sensitive to both choice and chance: what determines outcomes is how leaders and followers respond to the challenges/incentives/constraints provided by structure.

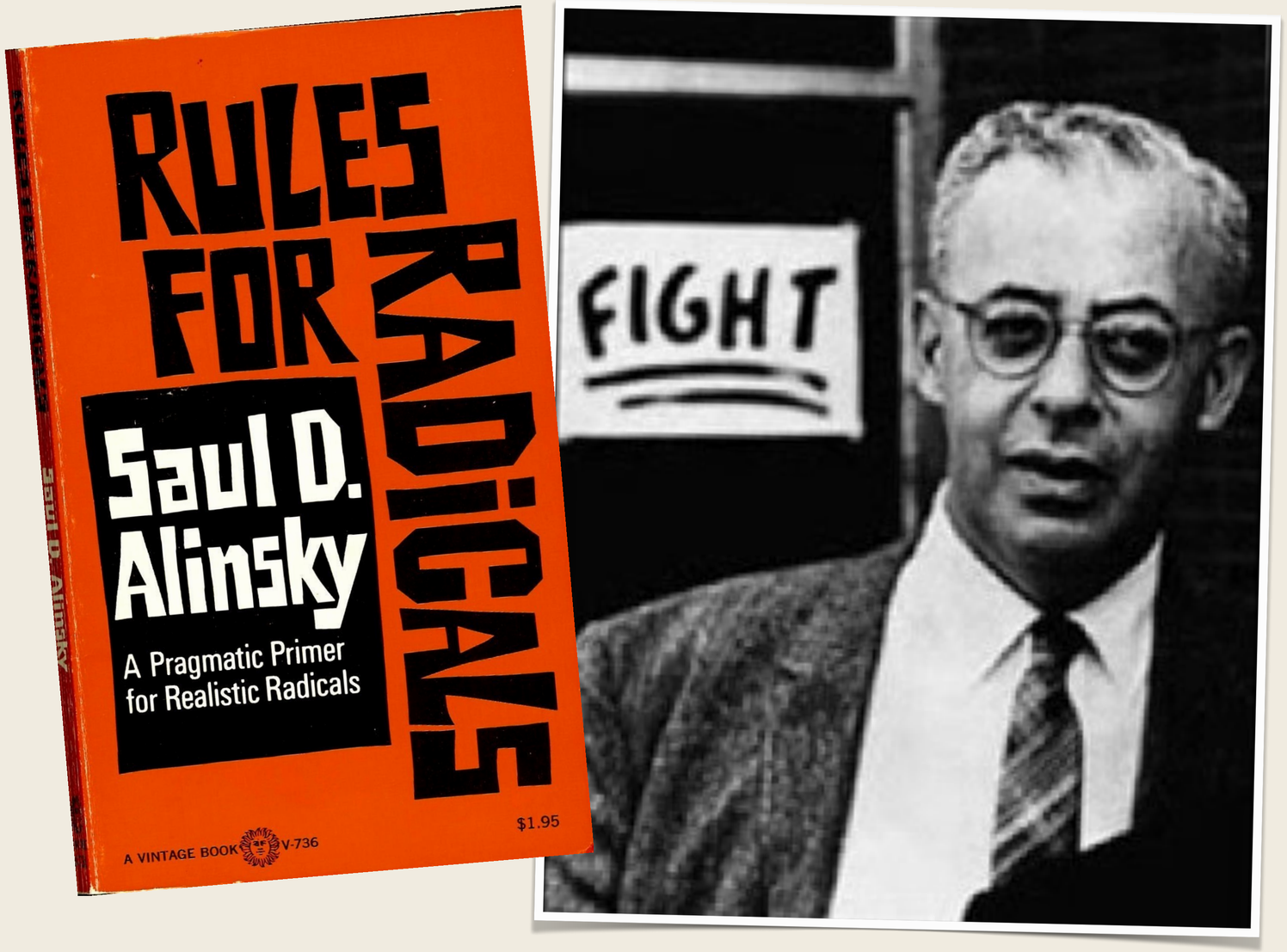
One of the implications of this, we said, is that the "means" or "tactics" used are key.

The question for today is: What "means"?

SAUL ALINSKY

The reading assigned for today is Saul Alinsky's famous *Rules for Radicals*, originally published in 1971.

Alinsky (1909-72) was a well-known Jewish-American left-wing activist, who helped organize workers and minorities for a variety of causes.



SAUL ALINSKY

Today, Alinsky is seen by American right-wing conservatives (most of whom have never read his work) as a kind of evil figure.

When Barack Obama was president, there were loads of conspiracy theories that painted him as an Alinsky disciple, using underhanded tactics to pursue a secret radical/socialist agenda. The link was that Obama also had been a so-called "community organizer" before entering electoral politics.

See here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dRae_JSWi-4

The main reasons for Alinsky's notoriety:

1) Controversial views on means and ends;

2) His tactics actually work.

RULES FOR RADICALS

Lest we forget at least an over-the-shoulder acknowledgment to the very first radical: from all our legends, mythology, and history (and who is to know where mythology leaves off and history begins—or which is which), the first radical known to man who rebelled against the establishment and did it so effectively that he at least won his own kingdom—Lucifer.

The dedication of Alinsky's book

RULES FOR RADICALS

The first chapter deals with “The Purpose”—intended both as the purpose of the book and the purpose of struggle.

The first sentence:

> What follows is for those who want to change the world from what it is to what they believe it should be. *The Prince* was written by Machiavelli for the Haves on how to hold power. *Rules for Radicals* is written for the Have-Nots on how to take it away.

Argues that “mankind” is divided in “three parts: the Haves, the Have-Nots, and the Have-a-Little, Want Mores.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

The "Haves:"

They enjoy "power, money, food, security, and luxury," want to keep things as they are. They are always the fewest, but on their side are "justice, morality, law, and order [...] mere words when used by the Haves, which justify and secure their status quo."

The "Have-Nots:"

They have strength in numbers, that's all.

The "Have-a-Little, Want Mores:"

Calls them "political schizoids:" "Torn between upholding the status quo to protect the little they have, yet wanting change so they can get more, they become split personalities."

RULES FOR RADICALS

In modern societies, the "Have-a-Little, Want Mores", a.k.a. the middle class, are the majority of the population (in developed societies). Most great revolutionary leaders have come from this group. Overall, however, most of them are part of what Alinksy calls the "Do-Nothings":

> These Do-Nothings profess a commitment to social change for ideals of justice, equality, and opportunity, and then abstain from and discourage all effective action for change. They are known by their brand, 'I agree with your ends but not your means.'

The problem: too much concern with "morality" of means will lead to the triumph of "immoral" ends.

RULES FOR RADICALS

The most controversial part of the book is the discussion "Of Means and Ends."

Alinsky starts by saying that the question "does the end justify the means" is "meaningless;" the real question should be: "Does this particular end justify these particular means?"

He continues by saying that "corrupt means" do not "corrupt the ends," as "he who fears corruption fears life."

In fact, a real "man of action" should always be willing to become "corrupt" and therefore sacrifice his own conscience for the well-being of others.

Those who won't simply don't "care enough for people to be 'corrupted' for them."

RULES FOR RADICALS

Alinsky's view is that: "The man of action views the issue of means and ends in pragmatic and strategic terms. He has no other problem; he thinks only of his actual resources and the possibilities of various choices of action. He asks of ends only whether they are achievable and worth the cost; of means, only whether they will work."

Those who are overly concerned with the "ethics" of means end up being allies of "the Haves", who benefit from the unwillingness of the "Have-Nots" to take effective action.

What Alinsky is saying is that "morality" is for poor people—a way to keep them from pursuing what is in their interest.

RULES FOR RADICALS

Of course, this doesn't mean that all means are good to achieve all ends—just how "immoral" or "corrupt" one's means can or should be depends on the ends and the options available. Suggests a series of rules about means and ends:

1. "One's concern with the ethics of means and ends varies inversely with one's personal interest in the issue:" meaning that one's willingness to use "unethical" means is greater when there is more at stake for them personally.

2. "The judgment of the ethics of means is dependent upon the political position of those sitting in judgment." Whether something is "ethical" or not often depends on who does it. At the end of the day, all that matters is the question of who wins/loses.

RULES FOR RADICALS

Illustrates the point with a discussion of the 1776 “Declaration of Independence.”

Alinsky notes that while for Americans this is a “glorious document and an affirmation of human rights,” for the British “it was a statement notorious for its deceit by omission,” because it listed none of the benefits the colonists had received from Britain.

Alinsky points out that the “Declaration” was a call for war, so providing “a list of many of the constructive benefits of the British Empire to the colonists would have so diluted the urgency of the call to arms for the Revolution as to have been self-defeating.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

He continues:

> The result might well have been a document attesting to the fact that justice weighted down the scale at least 60 per cent on our side, and only 40 per cent on their side; and that because of that 20 per cent difference we were going to have a Revolution. To expect a man to leave his wife, his children, and his home, to leave his crops standing in the field and pick up a gun and join the Revolutionary Army for a 20 per cent difference in the balance of human justice was to defy common sense.
>
> The Declaration of Independence, as a declaration of war, had to be what it was, a 100 per cent statement of the justice of the cause of the colonists and a 100 per cent denunciation of the role of the British government as evil and unjust. Our cause had to be all shining justice, allied with the angels; theirs had to be all evil, tied to the Devil; in no war has the enemy or the cause ever been grey.

RULES FOR RADICALS

3. “In war the end justifies almost any means.”

Alinsky cites Churchill’s comment on being allied with Stalin’s USSR in WW2: “I have only one purpose, the destruction of Hitler, and my life is much simplified thereby. If Hitler invaded Hell I would make at least a favorable reference to the Devil in the House of Commons.”

4. “Judgment must be made in the context of the times in which the action occurred and not from any other chronological vantage point.”

This also suggests that leaders should be adaptable and change with the times, be willing to be inconsistent. Consistency is not a virtue.

RULES FOR RADICALS

5. “Concern with ethics increases with the number of means available and vice versa.” When many options are available, one has the luxury to pick and choose the most “moral,” but not when options are more limited. Adds: “To me ethics is doing what is best for the most.”

6. “The less important the end to be desired, the more one can afford to engage in ethical evaluations of means.”

7. “Generally success or failure is a mighty determinant of ethics.”

Winners have a way to be viewed more favorably: “There can be no such thing as a successful traitor, for if one succeeds he becomes a founding father.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

8. “The morality of a means depends upon whether [it is] employed at a time of imminent defeat or imminent victory.” Illustrates with discussion of atomic bombs dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

9. “Any effective means is automatically judged by the opposition as being unethical.”

10. This is perhaps the most key: “You do what you can with what you have and clothe it with moral garments.” Alinsky explains:

> Moral rationalization is indispensable at all times of action whether to justify the selection or the use of ends or means. [...] All great leaders, including Churchill, Gandhi, Lincoln, and Jefferson, always invoked ‘moral principles’ to cover naked self-interest [...] All effective actions require the passport of morality.

RULES FOR RADICALS

Alinsky elaborates on this point with a discussion of the hero of Indian independence, Mohandas ("Mahatma," or "The Great") Gandhi, widely seen as an icon of non-violence (*ahimsa*), which has been elevated to a moral standard to which polite international discourse holds most movements who struggle against dictatorship and oppression.

Alinksy demolishes two myths about Gandhi:

1) That his tactics were chosen because they were the most "moral," showing instead they were chosen because they were most effective; and

2) That non-violence is a universal model applicable everywhere.

RULES FOR RADICALS

On the first issue, Alinsky makes a fundamental point. In his struggle against the British colonial occupiers, Gandhi had no guns, while the British did.

Had he had guns, moreover, Gandhi would have had no-one to use them.

Alinsky adds that Gandhi's own writings also contain a pragmatic assessment of the human capital he had to work with: a dispossessed, passive, demoralized mass of people.

Also cites a passage in Gandhi's writings that condemn the British for sapping Indian spirit by forcing "compulsory disarmament," which "has made us unmanly [...] has made us think we cannot look after ourselves."

RULES FOR RADICALS

Alinsky concludes: “These words more than suggest that if Gandhi had had the weapons for violent resistance and the people to use them this means would not have been so unreservedly rejected as the world would like to think.”

Alinsky argues that Gandhi’s choice of non-violent methods of passive resistance was based exclusively on pragmatic considerations, as the most effective means available:

To oversimplify, what Gandhi did was to say:

“Look, you are all sitting there anyway—so instead of sitting there, why don’t you sit over here and while you’re sitting, say Independence Now!”

RULES FOR RADICALS

On the second point, Alinsky argues that Gandhi's methods can only be successful in some contexts:

"His enemy was a British administration characterized by an old, aristocratic, liberal tradition, one which granted a good deal of freedom to its colonials," including freedom of the press.

"Gandhi's passive resistance would never have had a chance against a totalitarian state such as that of the Nazis."

Cites George Orwell: "Without a free press and right of assembly it is impossible, not merely to appeal to outside opinion, but to bring a mass movement into being, or even to make your intentions known to your adversary."

RULES FOR RADICALS

Before going into specific tactics, Alinsky covers a number of issues that are important for radical organizers.

One of the striking things is that Alinsky, while advocating “radical” tactics, was not really a radical himself w/ regard to ideology. In fact, he advocates a pragmatic approach founded on the pursuit of compromise:

> But to the organizer, compromise is a key and beautiful word. It is always present in the pragmatics of operation. [...] If you start with nothing, demand 100 per cent, then compromise for 30 per cent, you're 30 per cent ahead. [...] If I had to define a free and open society in one word, the word would be ‘compromise’.

RULES FOR RADICALS

As for ideology, suggests activists should keep a distance, “in order not to slip into becoming a true believer.”

“What I am saying is that the organizer must be able to split himself into two parts—one part in the arena of action where he polarizes the issue to 100 to nothing, and helps to lead his forces into conflict, while the other part knows that when the time comes for negotiations that it really is only a 10 per cent difference.”

Distance from ideology also makes one “unlikely to disintegrate into cynicism and disillusionment, for he does not depend on illusion.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

Finally, Alinsky gets to the issue of "tactics," defined as "doing what you can with what you have." Here are some of his rules:

1. "Power is not only what you have but what the enemy thinks you have." Can and should involve the use of disinformation.

2. "Never go outside the experience of your people. When an action or tactic is outside the experience of the people, the result is confusion, fear, and retreat. It also means a collapse of communication."

This rule applies more generally to communication, to which Alinsky also dedicates a lot of space. On this point, he argues that people only learn through the prism of their experience, so an organizer has to use language, symbols, tactics that followers can understand, relate to, and feel comfortable with

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A controversial passage deals with the famous "Boston Massacre" (1770) in which British soldiers killed 5 protesters. This was one of the sparks of the American Revolution (1776).

Gives some credence to theory that: a) The soldiers shot in self-defense, but were effectively blamed by colonists; b) The incident was planned by Samuel Adams for that purpose.

"It is what was implicit in the reputed statement of that organizational genius Samuel Adams, at the time when he was allegedly planning the Boston Massacre; he was quoted as saying that there ought to be no less than three or four killed so that we will have martyrs for the Revolution, but there must be no more than ten, because after you get beyond that number we no longer have martyrs but simply a sewage problem."

RULES FOR RADICALS

3. “Wherever possible go outside of the experience of the enemy. Here you want to cause confusion, fear, and retreat.”

4. “Make the enemy live up to their own book of rules. You can kill them with this, for they can no more obey their own rules than the Christian church can live up to Christianity.” Later, he adds: “For example, since the Haves publicly pose as the custodians of responsibility, morality, law, and justice, they can be constantly pushed to live up to their own book of morality and regulations.”

5. Related to this, he says: “Ridicule is man’s most potent weapon. It is almost impossible to counterattack ridicule. Also it infuriates the opposition, who then react to your advantage.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

6. “A good tactic is one that your people enjoy. If your people are not having a ball doing it, there is something very wrong with the tactic.”

7. “A tactic that drags on too long becomes a drag. Man can sustain militant interest in any issue for only a limited time, after which it becomes a ritualistic commitment, like going to church on Sunday mornings. New issues and crises are always developing, and one's reaction becomes, ‘Well, my heart bleeds for those people and I'm all for the boycott, but after all there are other important things in life’—and there it goes.”

8. “Keep the pressure on, with different tactics and actions, and utilize all events of the period for your purpose.”

9. “The threat is usually more terrifying than the thing itself.”

RULES FOR RADICALS

10. “The major premise for tactics is the development of operations that will maintain a constant pressure upon the opposition. It is this unceasing pressure that results in the reactions from the opposition that are essential for the success of the campaign. It should be remembered not only that the action is in the reaction but that action is itself the consequence of reaction and of reaction to the reaction, ad infinitum. The pressure produces the reaction, and constant pressure sustains action.”

This means:

a) Use multiple tactics;

b) Never use one tactic for too long; and

c) Be adaptable in reacting to events.

RULES FOR RADICALS

13. “Pick the target, freeze it, personalize it, and polarize it.”

What Alinsky means by this is that society is very complex, so when trying to assign blame for something wrong, it will rarely be the fault of any one person.

However, activists must not get bogged down in these complexities. They must pick a target (generally the most vulnerable) and focus all your energy on it, ignoring all the others who might be to blame.

It is also important that the target be an actual person, as it is much harder to generate hostility and other negative emotions towards inanimate structures or systems.

RULES FOR RADICALS

The step that comes after identifying and "freezing" the target is to "polarize" it. What that means is that the struggle must be defined in terms of "us vs. them", where us=100% good and them=100% bad; also, anyone who is not 100% with the movement is to be considered against it.

In this effort, one must ignore the fact that the target is not really 100% bad. Everyone has good/bad in them, but the organizer cannot afford this nuanced complexity, because followers are not likely to make great personal sacrifices to fight someone who is only, say, 60% bad.

That means that enemies need to be remade into devils and anyone who is not 100% with the movement into "devil appeasers."

RULES FOR RADICALS

Alinsky offers several examples of how these tactical rules can be combined effectively. Also, he goes into a discussion of the "anatomy of power among the Haves," which the Have Nots and their leaders have to understand and exploit.

On this point, he argues that the Haves are motivated by the fear of losing power and the desire for more power. This puts them not only in constant conflict with the Have Nots, but also in constant competition with other Haves. It is this internal competition that makes the Haves vulnerable:

> The internecine struggle among the Haves for their individual self- interest is as shortsighted as internecine struggle among the Have-Nots. I have on occasion remarked that I feel confident that I could persuade a millionaire on a Friday to subsidize a revolution for Saturday out of which he would make a huge profit on Sunday even though he was certain to be executed on Monday.

RULES FOR RADICALS

Alinsky provides a series of examples of how protest leaders have failed to understand/exploit the competition for power among the Haves.

On the whole, Alinsky's approach treats protest as "event-driven"—a chain of action and reaction between a social movement and its opposition that is very much open to choice, creativity, and innovation on both sides.

The challenge for a social movement is to turn its own weaknesses into strengths, turn its opponents' strengths into weaknesses, and precipitate events by frequently shifting tactics, goading opponents into making mistakes and discredit themselves, as well as by constantly keeping the pressure on opponents and a sense of excitement high among its own supporters.

RULES FOR RADICALS

The key is to be flexible and adaptable, which allows movements to respond to events as they unfold, instead of insisting on a plan that remains fixed regardless of the circumstances. Also, aggressiveness in rhetoric and tactics must be accompanied by pragmatic attitude and openness to compromise.

Accomplishing this determines whether or not a social movement will manage to take advantage of structural opportunities.

An effective movement is one that doesn't wait for conditions to be just right, but creates its own opportunities by taking actions that aim to divide and destabilize the opposition.

We can watch this and this if we have time. Keep in mind these are from 1971.